Therefore, developing a sharper sense of geopolitics can certainly contribute to building ties with India.

India and Japan are admittedly two very different societies, each with its own distinct history, sociology and culture. In the past, their distance was accentuated by the pulls and pressures of international politics. They have no history of significant differences in the past, yet took many years to develop a substantive agenda. Their civic culture, political ethos and even hedging mentality are all very different. But shared interests, common values and global responsibility are beginning to close the previous distance. It is not just with government; even Japanese business see the value of a stronger India. Both countries are striving hard to find shared ground and have exceeded expectations in that effort. As a result, it has taken just a few years for this to be seen as the most natural strategic equation in Asia. The challenge is to make it among the more substantive ones as well. And more than that with any other major relationship, time is at a premium.

There are important lessons from Japanese history that could impinge on the future of Asia, and thus of India. From the Meiji era onwards, that country has always leveraged the international environment. It has also responded to global power equations and always found partners to improve its position. That tradition surely continues. Japan actually has an India history and its logic may unfold once global impediments are removed. The end of the Cold War and now developments in its American alliance may be relevant in that regard. After 1945, Japan did not give up on the world but chose instead to pursue influence through economic means. It did so on the basis of assumptions that may no longer be entirely valid. With a history of embracing change, it could do so again if circumstances so compel.

Japan may hold much of the potential for change, but the ASEAN remains India’s gateway to the East. In fact, as it progresses in that direction, the basics of its approach must be continuously refreshed and underlined. There is a lot that India has learnt and continues to learn from that region. More than any other grouping, ASEAN has constantly adjusted to the larger global environment, even as they forged ahead with their regional integration and national progress. Through its very creation, ASEAN had